

Philadelphia's Academy of Natural Sciences Museum Closes, Prompting Efforts to Reopen

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-03 5 min read

Philadelphia's Academy of Natural Sciences Museum closed on September 30, 2026, leaving families and community leaders asking whether its public exhibits can return. The announcement came on September 1, giving visitors about a month to make a final trip.

Founded in 1812, the Academy opened to the public in 1828. It became the first place in the world to display a dinosaur skeleton in 1868. Its exhibits also included mammal **dioramas**, which are scenes showing animals in their habitats, live animals and changing displays.

Drexel University took financial responsibility for the Academy in 2011. It said costs rose and attendance fell after the pandemic. Drexel has faced its own financial pressures, including declining university enrollment and a budget shortfall reported in 2024.

The museum reduced hours and laid off some staff in 2025. It later canceled its 2026 summer camp. Yet attendance surged during its final weeks, and **revenue** was more than 20 times higher than the previous September.

Supporters held rallies and marches and gathered more than 114,000 petition signatures. Some criticized Drexel for giving little notice and not explaining what keeping the museum open would cost. Drexel said it remained committed to protecting the Academy's **legacy**.

Less than a week before closing, the William Penn Foundation offered a year of **bridge funding**: temporary money intended to allow time to find a lasting solution. Drexel said it was exploring that possibility but would need a plan for long-term financial stability before considering reopening.

The Academy's collection contains more than 19 million specimens, including plant samples gathered by Lewis and Clark. It also holds 73,000 **holotypes**, preserved reference samples scientists use to define and name species. Drexel says students and researchers will retain access, but access for the general public remains uncertain.

Philadelphia's city council proposed **zoning** changes that would make selling the building or converting it to other uses harder. It also plans public hearings to investigate the closure and possible solutions. These efforts leave the museum's future an open question.

Word Treasure

dioramas -- Displays showing scenes, such as animals in their habitats.

revenue -- Money an organization brings in before subtracting costs.

bridge funding -- Temporary money that allows time to seek a lasting financial solution.

holotypes -- Preserved reference specimens used to define and name species.

zoning -- Local rules about how land and buildings may be used.

legacy -- The lasting importance of an organization's history and work.

Background you need

Dioramas show scenes of animals in their habitats.

Bridge funding provides temporary support while a lasting solution is explored.

Holotypes serve as reference specimens for defining and naming species.

Break it down

Introduces the closure date and the notice given to visitors.

Describes the Academy's history and educational exhibits.

Explains financial pressures, service cuts and the final attendance surge.

Presents supporters' criticism and Drexel's response.

Explains the bridge funding offer and reopening conditions.

Ends with collection access, proposed zoning changes and planned hearings.

Why it matters

The closure limits public visits to a longstanding natural history museum. The funding offer and city proposals concern whether its exhibits can reopen while its scientific collection remains available for study.

Test what you remember

1. What did the Academy first display in 1868?
 - (A) A dinosaur skeleton
 - (B) A railway engine
 - (C) A telescope collection
 - (D) A spacecraft model
2. What financial pressures did Drexel say followed the pandemic?
 - (A) Falling costs and rising attendance
 - (B) Rising costs and rising attendance
 - (C) Rising costs and falling attendance
 - (D) Falling costs and falling attendance
3. What happened to attendance during the museum's final weeks?
 - (A) It stayed about the same.
 - (B) It rose sharply during the period.
 - (C) It declined throughout the period.
 - (D) It stopped being counted entirely.
4. What would the foundation's bridge funding allow time for?
 - (A) Building a new university campus
 - (B) Finding a lasting financial solution
 - (C) Replacing all the museum's exhibits
 - (D) Moving the collection to another city
5. What are holotypes used for?
 - (A) Setting prices for museum tickets
 - (B) Defining and naming species
 - (C) Counting visitors to public exhibits
 - (D) Planning changes to local zoning
6. What would the proposed zoning changes make harder?
 - (A) Selling the building or changing its use
 - (B) Displaying skeletons or teaching visitors
 - (C) Holding hearings or gathering signatures
 - (D) Studying specimens or naming species

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Drexel University: Drexel said it remained committed to the Academy's legacy and needed a plan for long-term financial stability before considering reopening.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):